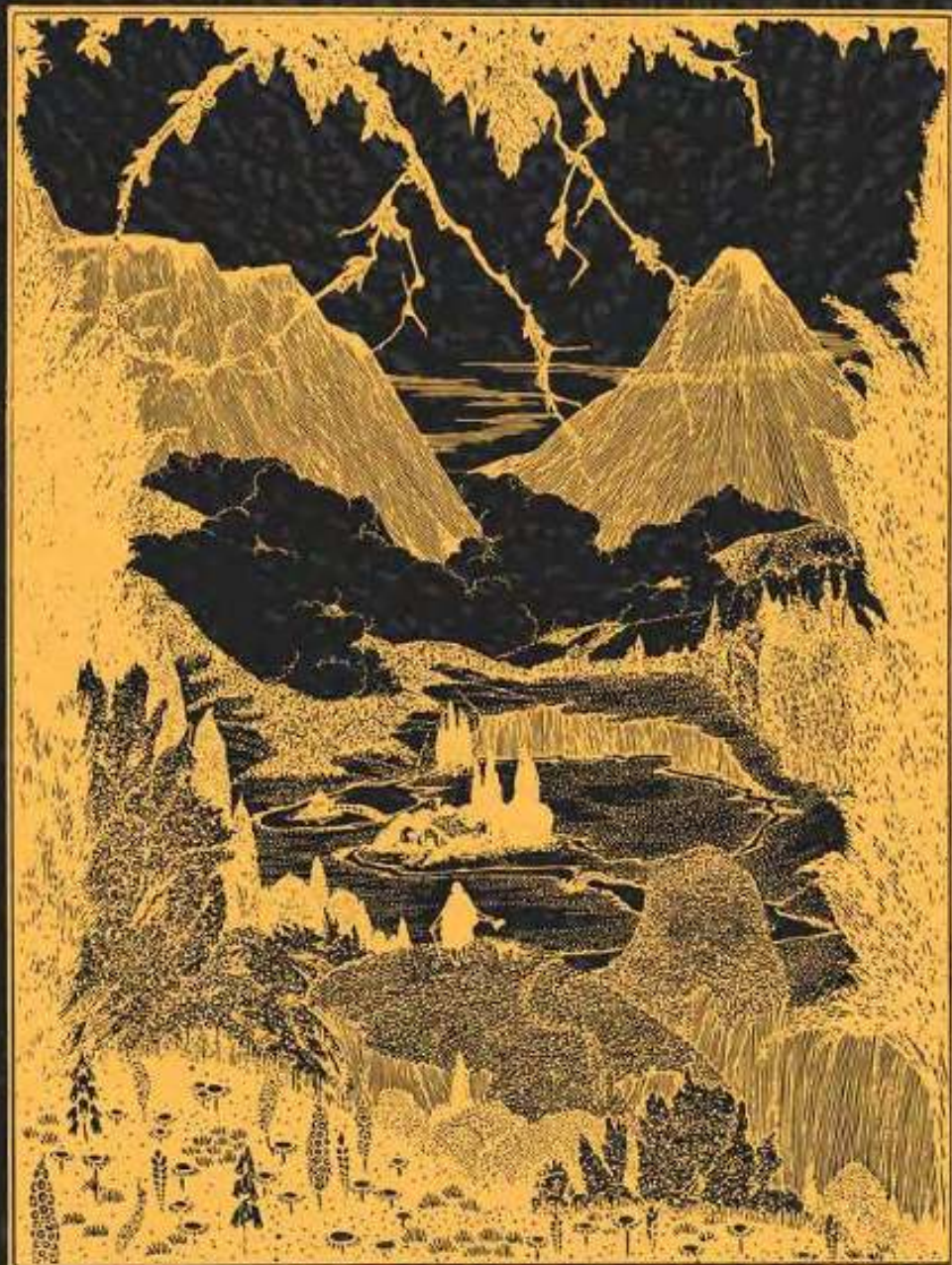


WEST MARCHES

CAMPAIGN PLAYSTYLE GUIDEBOOK



KARL OTTO KRISTOFFERSEN

WEST MARCHES

CAMPAIGN PLAYSTYLE GUIDEBOOK



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Feedback are most welcome, thank you for the comments so far!

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FOREWORD

This book is the one I wish I had when I started playing my first West Marches campaign. A simple, practical guide that describes the concept of this playstyle. I hope it helps you start your own game with confidence and excitement.

The West Marches style was created by smart, creative people long before I ran my first campaign. What I offer builds on their insights, framed through my own experience running a West Marches game at my friendly local game store,

This guide is written for the Game Master (GM), however anyone looking to organize, run, or simply understand how these games work will benefit from breezing through these pages.

Although the implied setting in this book is fantasy, it's written to be system-neutral, so you can use it with your favorite roleplaying game.

Enjoy!

Karl Otto Kristoffersen

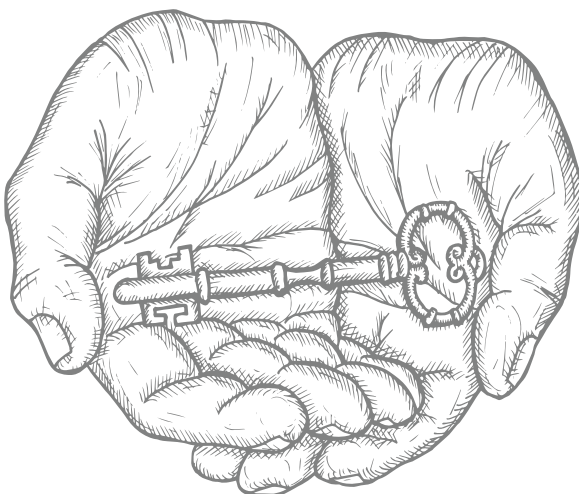


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- **CHAPTER 2: STARTING YOUR WEST MARCHES CAMPAIGN**

This chapter shows you how to build your starting town, sketch your wilderness, and set the stage for adventure.

- **CHAPTER 3: HOW TO RUN A WEST MARCHES SESSION**

Here's how to run each expedition, from the first steps out of town to the moment the players return (hopefully) in one piece.

- **CHAPTER 4: BETWEEN ADVENTURES**

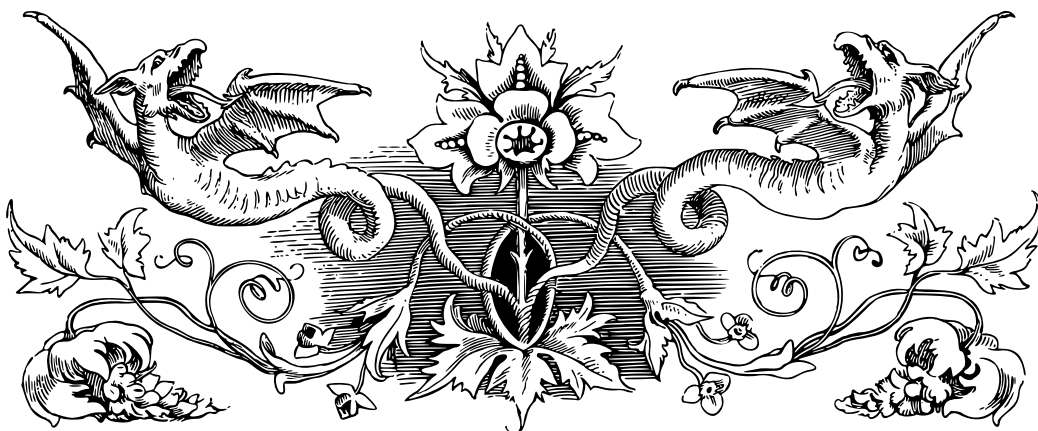
The story doesn't stop between sessions. Players heal, gather information, and help shape the world during downtime.

- **CHAPTER 5: TOOLS, TEMPLATES, AND TIPS FOR GMS**

This chapter gives you some practical tools, checklists, and shortcuts to keep prep light and sessions exciting.

- **CHAPTER 6: SAMPLE PLAY STRUCTURES AND FINAL ADVICE**

A collection of templatets, examples, and parting advice to help you run a West Marches campaign that's fun, flexible, and lasting.



WHAT IS WEST MARCHES PLAY?

A West Marches campaign is a style of roleplaying game that focuses on player freedom, open exploration, and group storytelling.

It's different from other playstyles because:

- **There is no fixed group**, different players can join different sessions
- **There is no storyline**, players choose where to go and what to do
- **The world changes over time**, what one group does, can affect others

Think of West Marches like a shared wilderness filled with secrets, monsters, ruins, and treasures. Everyone starts in the same home base (like a town or fort), but what happens outside the walls is totally up to the players.

It's a living world, where groups go out on expeditions and bring back stories.

THE ORIGIN STORY

The *modern* West Marches playstyle was formalized by a game designer named Ben Robbins in the early 2000s. He had a big group of friends who loved to play D&D, but with busy adult schedules and the usual “wait for the DM to tell us what to do” approach, things felt a bit slow and scripted. So he decided to try something different.

Instead of a story led by the GM, Ben built an open world filled with mysterious ruins, dangerous creatures, and scattered clues. And then gave all the power to the players. They would choose where to go, when to play, and who to bring. Every session started and ended in a safe town, and the world outside was wild and full of secrets. This campaign became the original West Marches.

After running that game for a couple of years, Ben wrote about it online, and his posts inspired GMs all over the world. Since then, West Marches has grown into a whole style of play where exploration, freedom, and player choice come first.

Whether you're discovering your first ruin or leading a faction across the frontier, you're now part of a tradition that started with one GM, a blank map, and a great idea.

"The players had to take the initiative. They had to pick a direction and say, 'We're going on an adventure!'"

- Ben Robbins,
creator of West Marches



For the original blog posts that inspired West Marches, see Ben Robbins' writings at his blog: <https://arsludi.lamemage.com>

A WORLD WAITING TO BE EXPLORED

West Marches is like a big map with lots of pins. Each game session is like putting one pin on that map: players go somewhere, explore something, and then come back. The rest of the map? Still waiting to be explored.

Here's what makes it special:

- **Exploration** is the heart of the game
- **Goals** are chosen by the players
- **Sessions** are one-shots with no required group or schedule
- **The world** is alive, what you do today changes what's there tomorrow
- **The GM** is a fair referee, they run the world, but don't control the story
- **Players** help build the story through teamwork, creativity, and sharing

So grab your map. Gather your gear. Rally a crew.
The frontier awaits.

CHAPTER 1:

CORE PRINCIPLES OF WEST MARCHES

This chapter introduces the six big ideas that make West Marches different from other RPG campaigns. These principles are the foundation for everything else in the book.

You'll learn:

1. **Why players set the goals and the pace of play**
2. **How exploration shapes the entire campaign**
3. **What makes town a safe, reliable reset point**
4. **How players share discoveries to grow the world**
5. **Why the GM runs the world but not the story**
6. **How only prepping one session at a time makes things smoother and more fun**

1. THE PLAYERS DRIVE THE GAME

In West Marches, the players lead the way. They decide where to go, what to explore, and what their characters hope to achieve. Each session begins with a player-driven goal, not a quest assigned by the GM.

Some groups prefer a set schedule (like "every Thursday at 6pm"), where whoever can attend joins the session. Others arrange sessions more freely. Either way, the players say what they want to do, the GM posts available time slots, and the available players form a party ready to play.

When the group has a goal in mind ahead of time, like exploring a ruin, the GM can prepare that specific location in advance. But even if no plan is made before game night, the GM isn't stuck. Instead, they use their tools of the trade: improvisation, random encounter tables, faction goals, weather events, and consequences from past sessions. The world doesn't wait, it moves, evolves, and reacts.

This flexibility is a strength. Sometimes you run a prepared location. Other times you play the world as it is. Either way, the game stays grounded in player choice, meaningful consequences, and a living setting.

Summary:

- *Players set their own goals and pace*
- *Players choose where to explore in the world*
- *The GM posts slots, prepares and improvises as the world reacts*



2. EXPLORATION IS THE GOAL

West Marches is all about exploring a dangerous world full of mystery. The players start in a safe town. Everything outside that town is unknown and filled with adventure. There might be haunted ruins, strange temples, dragon caves, or lost towers waiting to be discovered.

The players don't know what's out there until they go look. Also, the world is not "balanced". Some places are way too dangerous for low-level characters. That's part of the fun. If they stumble into a dragons lair early on... they probably shouldn't be there. And that's okay! They can retreat, warn others, and come back later better prepared.

The characters explore at their own risk. That's why finding treasure or making it home safely feels like a real accomplishment.

Summary:

- *The world is unknown, players explore to learn*
- *Some places are too dangerous early on*
- *Smart choices and teamwork are more important than raw power*

5. THE GM RUNS THE WORLD, NOT THE STORY

In West Marches, the Game Master is like a neutral referee or almost like a world simulator. They don't tell the story - the players do!

That means the GM doesn't:

- Give out main quests for the characters
- Tell players where to go
- Adjust encounters to match the party level

Instead, the GM:

- Makes sure the world reacts fairly
- Runs the monsters, weather, terrain, and time
- Allow the world to emerge through play

This is great for new GMs because you don't have to create a big plot. You just build a fun world, and the players explore it.

Summary:

- *The GM is neutral and doesn't lead the story*
- *They prepare the world and let players explore it*
- *They don't adjust danger levels, the world just is what it is*





6. ONLY PLAN ONE SESSION AT A TIME

Here's a big secret to making West Marches easy to run: Only prepare for one session at a time!

The players tell the GM where they want to go. The GM then preps that place, not the whole world.

There's no need to write big storylines. No need to build dungeons the players might never visit. Just wait until the players pick something they want to do, then prep that one thing.

This keeps the game fun, flexible, and fair. It also saves you from burning out.

Summary:

- *Let the players choose what they want to do*
- *Prep only the area they plan to explore*
- *No long story arcs unless players go there themselves*

CHAPTER 2: STARTING YOUR WEST MARCHES CAMPAIGN

Ready to launch your game?

This chapter walks you through setting up your world and inviting players to join the adventure.

You'll learn:

1. How to design a safe and simple starting town
2. Tips for sketching your wilderness and creating your first few locations
3. How to seed the world with rumors and hooks
4. What tools help keep your game organized
5. How to run a clear and helpful Session Zero for your players

Let's go!

1: CREATE A BASE OF OPERATIONS

Every West Marches campaign starts with a safe town, village, or fort. This is where every adventure begins and ends.

Think of it like the Keep in The Keep on the Borderlands - a sturdy, familiar place on the edge of danger. You venture out into the unknown, but you always return to regroup, rest, and prepare for what comes next.

Your town should have:

- A name and some flavor, e.g. "Greyford, a town built on the ruins of a bridge"
- A few key NPCs like shopkeepers, blacksmiths, or a town elder
- No combat, no danger, and no complicated storylines. It's peaceful, period

Players can buy things, heal, and talk to people for clues, but nothing dramatic should happen in town. You want it to be the calm place where players always feel safe.

Summary:

- *Keep town simple and useful*
- *Avoid adding enemies in town, the danger is always outside the walls*
- *Do not break the players trust*





2: SKETCH THE WILDERNESS

Now it's time to build the world outside the town. This is your adventure zone, a big open wilderness filled with cool stuff to discover.

You don't need to map out every tree. Just think about:

- Some terrain types: forest, swamp, hills, desert, icy wastes, etc.
- A few interesting locations: a ruined tower, a hidden cave, a sunken temple
- How far things are from town: nearby areas should be a little safer. The deeper you go, the scarier it gets

You can draw a hex map, or just sketch some regions. The players start knowing very little about what's out there. As they explore, the map gets filled in.

Summary:

- Start with just a handful of adventure locations near town
- Add rumors for areas they haven't been to yet, it will encourage exploration
- Leave room for player discovery, don't explain everything from the start

3: ADVENTURE HOOKS

At the start, the world is mostly blank. To help players get started, give them a few leads - things to be curious about.

Some examples:

- *"Old Tom says there's a treasure buried where three rivers meet."*
- *"A farmer saw tracks bigger than any bear near the Stonewoods."*
- *"The ruins west of town glow at night, and howls are heard in the wind."*

Put these rumors on a quest board in town or write them in a shared doc. Players can use these to pick their first goal.

Summary:

- *Keep the rumors short, mysterious, and a little vague*
- *Some might be true, or partially true, let the players find out*
- *Let players update the rumors as they explore the growing world*

4: SET UP SHARED TOOLS

Because West Marches is a shared world with different players at different times, it helps to keep everyone on the same page. You don't need anything fancy, just a few shared tools like:

- A shared map, a copy of the world players can update
- A quest board, showing rumors, unfinished dungeons, or open goals
- Session logs, short reports after each game
- A character list, showing who's who and what level they are

You can use Google Docs, a Discord server, a whiteboard, a physical notebook or whatever works for your group. Next up is making sure to use them.

Summary:

- *Ask players to help with updates! It's a team effort*
- *Keep it simple: a list of "What we know" is better than no notes at all*
- *Don't worry if it's messy, that's part of the charm*

5: INVITE AND EXPLAIN THE RULES

Now that you've got your world ready, it's time to gather your adventurers!

West Marches works best with a larger pool of players, maybe like 6 to 12 players, or even more. That way, there's always someone who can play.

At your Session Zero (your first meetup), explain how things work:

- *"You can play whenever you want, just make a group and plan a session."*
- *"Every adventure starts and ends in town."*
- *"There's no story I'm forcing on you, you choose what to do."*
- *"Some places are really dangerous. If you want to survive, work together."*

Help them build characters that make sense in the world. Everyone starts in town, knows it's a frontier, and is ready to explore.

A few big movers for the gaming experience:

Summary:

- *Encourage teamwork and sharing discoveries*
- *Remind them it's okay to fail. Running away can be smart*
- *Get them excited to explore. The world is theirs to uncover*



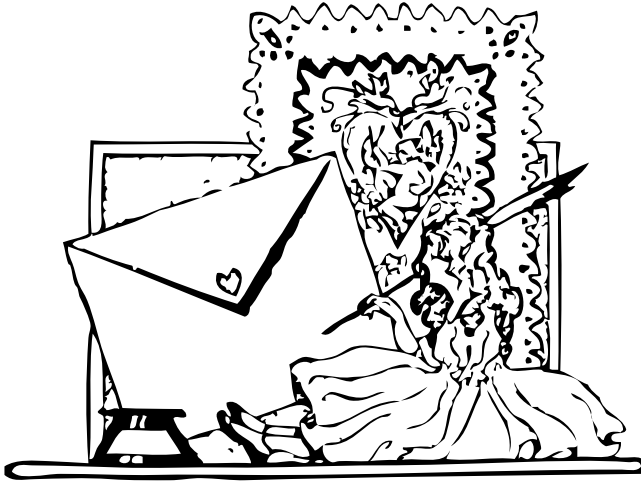
CHAPTER 3:

HOW TO RUN A WEST MARCHES SESSION

This chapter is your step-by-step guide to running a full session. From the moment players choose their goal to when they return to town.

You'll learn:

- 1. How to prep only what's needed for that session**
- 2. How to help the group get ready and stay focused**
- 3. How to run travel, exploration, encounters, and discoveries**
- 4. How to embrace character death**
- 5. How to end each expedition cleanly**
- 6. How to end the session with rewards, downtime, and reports**



1: PLANNING THE SESSION

Unlike regular campaigns where the GM schedules everything, in West Marches the players take the lead.

A player will say something like: *"Hey, want to go check out the tower ruins on Saturday night?"*. If enough people are interested, they gather a party and contact the GM. Then and only then does the GM begin preparing.

As the GM, ask the players:

- *Where do you want to go?*
- *What's your goal for this trip?*
- *Who's playing?*

Once you know that, you prepare only what's needed for that session. This keeps your workload light and makes the world feel responsive.

Summary:

- *If players don't know what to do, check the quest board or following a rumor*
- *Never force them to go somewhere specific*
- *If two groups want to explore the same place in different weeks, that's awesome!*

2: PREPARE THE GROUP

At the start of the session, gather everyone together and go over the basics.

Make sure the players:

- Introduce their characters
- State their plan and goal
- Double-check their gear (torches? rations? healing?)
- Appoint someone to take notes or write the session report

You can also remind them of:

- The known dangers in the region
- What time it is (e.g., "It's early spring, mid-morning")
- How long they'll be traveling (rough distance to goal)

Encourage them to plan carefully. In West Marches, resources matter, and poor planning can lead to disaster.

Summary:

- *Travel takes time! Make sure they leave enough to get home*
- *Encourage discussion - let them be cautious or bold as they choose*
- *Remind them they don't have to finish everything in one trip*



3: RUNNING THE EXPEDITION

Now the real adventure begins. The group leaves town and enters the wild. The world outside is dangerous, mysterious, and exciting. As the GM, your job is to present the world honestly. Don't protect the players - but don't be cruel either. Just let the world react to what they do.

Here's what to focus on:

Travel

- How long does it take to reach the destination?
- Are there weather effects, obstacles, or wandering monsters?
- Do they have enough food, light, and time?
- Use travel to build tension and give the sense that the world is alive and moving

Exploration

- What's the place like when they arrive?
- What can they see, hear, smell?
- Are there clues about what happened here in the past?
- Let players investigate, sneak, or talk things out. Encourage creativity

Encounters

- If combat happens, keep it fair but dangerous
- No fight is ever "balanced."
- Running away is okay!
- Sometimes a trap or puzzle is just as exciting as a battle
- Let smart ideas work and reward clever thinking. West Marches isn't about winning fights - it's about surviving and discovering.

And a few general recommendations during play:

- Don't fudge dice, let the players see real risks and rewards
- Don't over-plan, rather react to what players do
- Keep track of time. If they spend too long, night might fall or enemies might return...

4: EMBRACING CHARACTER DEATH

In West Marches, the wilderness is truly dangerous and character death is part of the game. Not every encounter is fair, and not every retreat comes in time. That's intentional.

Death adds weight to the world. It reminds everyone that choices matter and that the frontier is untamed and unforgiving. It also leads to some of the most powerful stories your group will ever tell.

Here's why character death belongs in West Marches:

- It raises the stakes. When players know death is possible, their decisions feel more meaningful.
- It encourages caution and planning. Players learn to scout, bring the right gear, and know when to turn back.
- It makes survival memorable. Victories feel earned, not guaranteed.
- It adds to the world's history. Fallen characters leave behind gear, rumors, unfinished goals, and legends.
- It creates space for new characters. A new explorer steps into the world with their own drive, shaped by the ones who came before.

Summary:

- Character death is part of meaningful play, not failure
- Let it happen, mark it in the world's history, and move forward
- This gives weight and spirit to the game





CHAPTER 4: **BETWEEN** **ADVENTURES**

What happens between sessions can be just as important as the adventures themselves. This chapter shows you how to manage downtime and world growth.

You'll learn:

- 1. How players can heal, craft, train, and prepare between sessions**
- 2. How to set up an adventurers' guild with upgrades and shared resources**
- 3. How to track and share information across the whole group**
- 4. Why gold should always matter, and how to make it useful**
- 5. How to let time pass in the world even when players aren't adventuring**



1. DOWNTIME ACTIVITIES

When a session ends and characters are safely back in town, they can take downtime actions. These are things the characters does during the “off-screen” time between adventures.

Downtime is flexible. The characters can choose one or more activities depending on how much time has passed or what your system allows.

Here are some common examples:

- **Rest and recover:** Heal, cure poison or disease, or recover lost ability points.
- **Craft items:** Potions, scrolls, weapons, traps.
- **Train skills or level up:** Spend gold or time to improve.
- **Research lore:** Learn more about ruins, enemies, or magic.
- **Gather information:** Listen to rumors in the tavern.
- **Hire help:** Pay for mercenaries, scouts, translators, or pack mules.
- **Contribute to the town:** Donate gold, build things, improve infrastructure.
- **Write and copy maps:** Share knowledge with the group.

Let players be creative. The goal is to give meaning to the time between adventures, and encourage characters to shape the world.

Summary:

- *You don't need strict rules. Use common sense and talk it through.*
- *Let downtime actions lead to new rumors, prices, or quests.*
- *Use a shared sheet or Discord thread to track who did what.*

2. THE ADVENTURERS' GUILD

West Marches works great when players feel like they're part of something bigger, even when they're not playing at the same time.

You can make an "Adventurers' Guild" that acts as a shared team or faction where all of the characters are members. The guild gives structure to the campaign and helps connect players across sessions.

Here's how a guild can work:

- Each character donates a small part of their loot (like 10%) to the guild
- That gold is pooled together to pay for upgrades that benefit everyone
- Players vote on what the guild should do with the gold

Examples of guild upgrades:

- Hire NPC support staff: A healer, cook, guide, or spy
- Upgrade the town: Add a forge, magical library, potion shop
- Unlock travel tools: Mounts, wagons, boats, teleportation circles
- Improve map and intel: Buy better maps, magic compasses, or pay scouts

Players love spending loot, and this gives them meaningful, group-wide options. It also makes town feel alive and evolving.

Summary:

- Add a simple "guild bank" tracker to your shared tools
- Let players suggest and vote on what to build or unlock
- The more they contribute, the more connected they feel





3. SHARING KNOWLEDGE

One of the most exciting things about West Marches is when players learn from each other, even if they weren't in the same session.

To support this, encourage everyone to:

- Write session reports (in-character or out-of-character)
- Update the shared map
- Mark known dangers, open dungeons, and rumored treasures

You can even have players copy magical symbols, draw maps, or leave notes for others in the world. The more tools they use to help each other, the more immersive the campaign feels.

Summary:

- Consider rewarding players who post reports or help others
- Let the guild offer gold or XP bonuses for writing reports or filling in maps
- Create a log of "discovered but incomplete" adventures



4. USING GOLD AND MAKING IT MATTER

In many roleplaying games, gold becomes meaningless after a few levels. In West Marches, it should always have a purpose.

Here's how to make spending gold feel useful and exciting:

- Healing or restoring stats costs money
- Upgrades to the guild or town require group funding
- Magical research or crafting requires rare ingredients and gold
- NPCs need payment for help, information, or services

This means every treasure hoard and every coin the players find has a purpose. It pushes the game forward.

Summary:

- *Avoid a magic item shop. Let powerful gear be found, not bought*
- *Let players spend gold to unlock story, like clues, maps, or special missions*
- *Offer cool downtime options that cost gold, like "Language Training" or "Secret Library Access."*

5. TIME KEEPS MOVING

Even when no session is happening, time in the world moves forward. Let weeks or months pass between sessions.

That means:

- Dungeons might get refilled.
- Enemies regroup or migrate.
- Rumors grow, fade, or change.
- New threats emerge, especially if left alone.

You don't need a perfect calendar. Just track time loosely. Maybe 1 week passes between sessions unless otherwise stated. That way, the world feels alive and things evolve based on player actions (or inaction).

Summary:

- Track downtime to balance long actions
- Let threats grow and change if left alone
- Passing time adds urgency and excitement to exploration



CHAPTER 5: TOOLS, TEMPLATES, AND TIPS FOR GMs

This chapter gives you some ready-to-use tools, checklists, and tips to stay organized, save prep time, and keep sessions exciting.

You'll learn:

1. What tools you need to track characters, time and discoveries
2. A simple prep checklist that works for every session
3. How to build encounters that feel fair, dangerous and dynamic
4. Templates for session reports, downtime actions and upgrades

2. SESSION PREP TEMPLATE

To keep things simple, prep only what's needed for the next session. Here's a quick template:

GM Prep Checklist:

- Ask players what they want to do
- Identify the location(s) involved

Prepare:

- The relevant locations or scenes
- A couple of combat encounters
- Any NPCs or strange discoveries
- Plan travel time and some weather or road events
- Track time (start date and expected days of travel)
- Review rumors, notes, and previous discoveries
- Create some new rumors or clues (in case they come back to town)

That's it!

Let the players fill in the rest with their choices and ideas.

Never prep a whole region in detail. Just the parts they're actively exploring. Build as they uncover it.



3. DESIGNING ENCOUNTERS

Because players choose their own path, you can't always predict what they are doing and who they will fight. That's okay!

West Marches is built on the idea that:

- Some fights are too hard
- Running away is okay
- Smart players avoid or outwit danger

When making encounters, think about:

- Threat level: How scary is this? Can they handle it?
- Clues and signs: Are there hints before it starts?
- Escape routes: Can they run if things go bad?
- Tactical choices: Can terrain or traps be used smartly?

You don't need every fight to be deadly, just meaningful. That could mean an angry druid who wants them out of her woods, a group of lost goblins, or a massive beast guarding something ancient.

Instead of purely "random" encounters, use "planned reactions."

Ask: "What's moving in this part of the world when the players enter it?"



4. TEMPLATES

Session Report Template (for players)

- Date:
- Party Members:
- Goal:
- Route Taken:
- What We Found:
- Monsters Encountered:
- Loot Gained:
- What's Still There:
- Rumors/Leads:
- Notes for Future Expeditions:

Downtime Action Template

- Character:
- Downtime Action Taken:
- Days Spent:
- Gold Spent:
- Effect or Result:

Guild or Town Upgrade Proposal

- Proposed By:
- Upgrade Name:
- Gold Cost:
- Effect:
- Why It Helps:
- Other Notes:

Encourage players to fill these out themselves!
It's part of the fun.

CHAPTER 6:

SAMPLE PLAY STRUCTURES AND FINAL ADVICE

This final chapter pulls everything together with templates, examples, and closing advice to help your West Marches campaign last.

You'll learn:

1. **How to onboard new players with a simple welcome sheet**
2. **What a good session report looks like**
3. **A one-page campaign startup checklist**
4. **Tips for long-term success and group coordination**
5. **A few ideas on how to expand the world**
6. **Final thoughts to inspire confident, flexible play**

1. SAMPLE PLAYER-FACING DOCUMENT

You can hand this out, copy the text to post it online, or read it aloud in your Session Zero.

"Welcome to the West Marches!"

This is an open-world, player-driven campaign. You'll explore ancient ruins, battle monsters, uncover treasure, and shape the world — all on your own terms.

Here's what you need to know:

- *You decide what to do and where to go.*
- *You form your own groups with a player cap of X players each session*
- *All adventures begin and end in Town.*
- *The world changes based on what you do.*
- *Share maps, rumors, and discoveries with other players.*
- *Not every fight is fair — running away is wise.*
- *After each session, someone writes a report.*
- *Downtime actions help you prepare between adventures.*

To join:

- *Make a character using [RULESET]*
- *Join the group chat/server/document*
- *Check the quest board and plan an expedition*
- *Go adventure, have fun, and share what you find!"*

2. EXAMPLE SESSION REPORT

Reports don't have to be long, they just need to pass on useful info.

Session Report – “The Tower in the Fog”

Date: May 3

Party: Yasha, Berrick, Minnow, and Dugo

Goal: Explore the strange tower north of Mistfen

Route: Through Marsh Road and South Ridge

What We Found:

- *An ancient wizard's tower, partially collapsed*
- *Arcane traps still active*
- *Lower floor had magical books, now in guild archive*

Enemies:

- *3 bandit-scouts from the South Ridge area*
- *A cursed statue that animated when touched*

Treasure:

- *2 spell scrolls*
- *80 GP in old silver*

What's Left:

- *Locked door in basement (didn't open it)*
- *Upper floors unexplored due to risk*

Notes:

- *Fog grows thick near tower at sunset - may be magical*
- *Return with more magic protection next time*

3. CAMPAIGN KICKOFF CHECKLIST

Here's a one-page checklist to start your West Marches campaign strong:

World Setup

- Safe starting town with shops and NPCs
- 3–5 nearby locations to explore
- Sketch of a large, open wilderness
- At least 5 rumors or story seeds
- Shared map (digital or physical)

Player Setup

- Clear welcome sheet or campaign rules
- Character creation guide
- Group chat or coordination hub
- Quest board or rumor log
- Session report system

GM Setup

- Prep one small area for Session One
- Build session prep sheet and time tracker
- Prepare downtime and guild bank tracking
- World clock or calendar (optional)

Session Zero Goals

- Explain the core principles
- Introduce tools and how to join games
- Help players make characters
- Start planning the first expedition!

4. LONG-TERM CAMPAIGN

Even the best sandbox campaigns can fizzle out without care. Here are some lasting tips:

Keep the world alive

- Let time pass and the world evolve
- Reward exploration, not just combat
- Allow consequences to shape new stories

Communicate often

- Post weekly updates or summaries
- Encourage players to invite new people to the pool
- Give praise and attention to session reports and discoveries

Refresh and expand

- Add new rumors, quests, and story threads
- Introduce new regions when interest slows
- Invite new GMs or rotate session types (e.g., mystery sessions, social events, survival one-shots)

Let players shape things

- Say “yes” when players want to build, invent, or lead
- Encourage faction building and in-world influence
- Give players chances to leave a legacy

5. EXPANDING THE WORLD

Eventually, your players may explore every corner of your first map. That's when you can expand the world beyond its original borders.

You don't need to build it all at once. Instead, let the expansion happen through story and discovery.

Ways to expand the world:

- Rumors of another continent, island chain, or underground kingdom
- A portal opens to a new region or forgotten realm
- A massive natural event reveals hidden areas (e.g. an earthquake uncovers ruins)

When expanding, treat it like you did at the start:

- Sketch a new region with a few new areas
- Seed rumors and mystery
- Let the players explore at their own pace

To make it really exciting, you can create expansion zones that require certain tools or knowledge to enter, like flying ships, climbing gear, or translated texts.

